

Setting Up Claude Code

Desktop, Terminal, VS Code, and Positron

Yale Library | StatLab

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Setup Goal

By the end of this guide, you should have:

- A Claude account
- Claude Desktop installed
- Claude Code available from your terminal
- The Claude Code extension available in VS Code or Positron

For the workshop, I will use **Step 7: the Claude Code extension inside Positron.**

Need Help?

These steps are written to be self-contained — give them a try first! Most installations go smoothly, and the Common Issues slide at the end covers the most frequent hiccups.

Still stuck before the workshop?

Ted Ellsworth is happy to help. Book a setup appointment at Marx Library [here](#) and include a note in the title that you are coming for pre-workshop support.

General questions — reach out anytime at statlab@yale.edu

After the workshop

StatLab offers free 1:1 consultations with methodological experts — a great resource for any research you are working on. Book a time with our team [here](#).

Official Download Links

Use the official links below.

Tool	Link
Claude account	claude.ai
Claude Desktop	claude.com/download
Node.js LTS	nodejs.org
VS Code	code.visualstudio.com/download
Positron	positron.posit.co/download.html
Claude Code docs	code.claude.com/docs

Step 1: Install Claude Desktop

1. Go to claude.com/download.
2. Download the installer for your computer.
3. Open Claude Desktop.
4. Sign in with your Claude account.

Claude Desktop is useful for chat, reading files you upload, and general writing help. Claude Code is the coding agent we will use for project files and terminal work.

Working location: Claude Desktop does not automatically use a project folder. Upload or attach the files you want Claude to discuss.

Windows users: Claude Desktop may ask for camera access on first launch. You can safely click **No** or **Don't allow** — camera is not used in this workshop.

Step 2: Install an Editor

Install at least one editor:

Editor	Use it if...
Positron	You work with R, Python, notebooks, data, or plots
VS Code	You already use VS Code or prefer a general code editor

For this workshop, **Positron is recommended** because it has an editor, terminal, R console, Python console, and plot pane in one place.

Step 3: Check Node.js

Claude Code can be installed through npm, which comes with Node.js.

Open a terminal and run:

```
node --version
```

If the version starts with v18 or higher, continue to the next step.

If you see an error, install the **LTS** version from nodejs.org, then close and reopen your terminal.

Step 4: Install Claude Code

Run this command in your terminal:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Then check that it worked:

```
claude --version
```

If you see a version number, Claude Code is installed.

Windows users: If the install fails with a permissions error, enable **Developer Mode** in Windows Settings (System → Developer Options), then re-run the command.

A Note on Permission Prompts

Several prompts will appear during setup — all expected:

- **“Do you trust the authors of this folder?”** → **Yes** (VS Code/Positron workspace trust for your own folder)
- **“Do you trust this extension?”** → **Yes** (Anthropic’s Claude Code extension)
- **“Allow this app to make changes to your device?”** → **Yes** (Windows UAC; needed to install extension files)
- **Camera access request** → **No** (Claude Desktop on Windows; not needed)

When in doubt: prompts about your own folder, an Anthropic extension, or file installs are safe to approve.

Step 5: Choose Your Working Folder

Claude Code works on the folder you open it in. Always navigate to your project folder before launching Claude Code.

Location	How to choose the working folder
Terminal	Run <code>cd path/to/project</code> before running <code>claude</code>
Positron	File menu, Open Folder, then choose your project folder
VS Code	File menu, Open Folder, then choose your project folder
Claude Desktop	Upload or attach the files you want to use

To confirm your terminal location:

```
pwd      # Mac
```

```
pwd      # Windows
```

Step 6: Sign In to Claude Code

Once you are in your project folder, run:

```
claude
```

The first launch may open a browser window. Sign in with your Claude account, then return to the terminal.

When Claude Code is ready, you will see a prompt where you can type.

Step 7: Add Positron's Claude Code Extension

This is the setup I will use for the workshop: **Claude Code extension inside Positron.**

In Positron:

1. File menu, Open Folder.
2. Choose the workshop or project folder.
3. Open the Extensions panel.
4. Search for **Claude Code**.
5. Install the official Claude Code extension.
6. Sign in if prompted.

The extension uses the folder you opened in Positron as its working location.

Optional: Terminal Inside Your Editor

You can also run Claude Code directly from the integrated terminal in Positron or VS Code.

1. Open your project folder.
2. Open the integrated terminal.
3. Run `claude`.

Useful shortcuts:

Editor	Open terminal
Positron	Terminal menu, then New Terminal
VS Code on Mac	Cmd + `
VS Code on Windows	Ctrl + `

Optional: Extension in VS Code

If you prefer VS Code:

1. File menu, Open Folder.
2. Choose your project folder.
3. Open the Extensions panel.
4. Search for **Claude Code**.
5. Install the official Claude Code extension.
6. Sign in if prompted.

Shortcuts for the Extensions panel:

System	Shortcut
Mac	Cmd + Shift + X
Windows	Ctrl + Shift + X

Step 8: Try a First Prompt

Open a project folder in Positron, then open the Claude Code extension.

At the Claude prompt, try:

```
What files are in this project? Give me a brief summary.
```

Claude should inspect the folder and summarize what it finds.

Readiness Checklist

You are ready for the workshop if each item works:

- Claude Desktop opens and you are signed in.
- `node --version` prints v18 or higher.
- `claude --version` prints a version number.
- `claude` launches from a terminal.
- Positron opens your workshop or project folder.
- The Claude Code extension is installed in Positron.

Common Issues

Problem	Try this
node not found	Install Node.js LTS from nodejs.org, reopen terminal
claude not found	Re-run <code>npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code</code>
npm install fails (Windows)	Enable Developer Mode (Windows Settings → System → Developer Options)
Sign-in loop	Run <code>claude logout</code> , then <code>claude login</code>
Extension not visible	Update Positron or VS Code, search again for Claude Code
Windows terminal problems	Use PowerShell or Windows Terminal

Quick Reference

Command	What it does
<code>node --version</code>	Check Node.js
<code>npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code</code>	Install or update Claude Code
<code>claude --version</code>	Check Claude Code
<code>claude</code>	Start Claude Code in the current folder
<code>/help</code>	Show Claude Code commands
<code>/clear</code>	Start a fresh Claude Code session
<code>/exit</code>	Leave Claude Code